take my place in the field.

Fielding has always been pure pleasure for me. Some batsmen do not share the sentiment, but ever since my high school days when Faf and I used to patrol the covers, I have always enjoyed the adrenalin rush of pacing in as each ball is bowled, primed to dive or swoop … It's not just fielding for me, it's hunting the ball.

During the first T20 international against New Zealand, which we won at Kingsmead, I experienced both sides of the fielding experience, nearly losing a tooth when the ball bounced up and struck me on the chin, and then leaping to my left to take a catch at mid-on.

We lost the second T20 at Centurion, though a significant consolation in defeat was the continuing emergence of Kagiso Rabada, a 20-year-old fast bowler educated at St Stithians, who had made his mark at the Under-19 Cricket World Cup in 2014 and was becoming a regular member of the national team. 'KG' has all the talent and athleticism required to be successful, but it is his strength of character that most impresses me. He works exceptionally hard in practice and in the nets, and he's eager to learn. I spent quite a bit of time with him, offering pieces of advice here and there, and I really enjoy his response when batsmen try to disrupt his rhythm: he simply fights fire with fire.

Moving into the ODI series, Hashim's century won us the game at SuperSport Park, and then Martin Guptill's innings took New Zealand to victory in Potchefstroom. The deciding match was played in Durban and, after a relatively barren run, I was pleased to score 68 in what unfolded as a reasonably decisive victory.

Our next assignment was a full two-month tour of India, which would include two T20 internationals, five one-day internationals and four Test matches, and I looked forward to playing in all three formats. People often ask whether I prefer five-day Tests, ODIs or T20 matches, and my response is dull and predictable: I enjoy all three.

Test cricket remains, figuratively and literally, the ultimate test and it